Chariots of Fire, Steel and Gold

For a sports-crazy nation, India has too slender a haul of world-conquering moments. Here are a few, all forged in fire



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INDIA PICTURE

Hockey Gold

London Olympics, 1948

A year into independence, India got a chance to test its traditional stick sorcery in a new age...also to see whether Partition had left it diminished. Despite that vivisected might, both sides were still individually so strong that India was widely expected to meet Pakistan in the final. But Great Britain, to everyone's surprise, beat Pakistan in the semis, and India ended up facing off against its old colonial rulers. So a chance to demonstrate superpower status was doubly sweet. The wizard Dhyan Chand, in his 40s, had just signed off on serious hockey, despite scoring 61 goals in 22 matches in East Africa in November '47. But the mesmerising skill and speed of another legend, Balbir Singh Sr, who scored two goals in the final, was enough to help India rout GB 4-0 for its first Olympic gold after Independence.



Milkha Singh

Rome Olympics, 1960

Milkha Singh's legacy goes beyond the trails he blazed. The 'Flying Sikh' epitomised the struggles of someone torn by the riots of 1947. A teenager left orphaned and uprooted, it was from that nowhere space that he overcame all odds to craft a future. Milkha started running only after he joined the army, in 1951, and within a few years, became one of the top 400m sprinters in the world. His feat at Rome 1960 remains among the greatest by any Indian track athlete. The time he clocked then, 45.6 seconds, was a national record for 38 years. Finishing fourth in a photo-finish was technically a loss, but the tracks he ran on to reach there were made of fire.

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